Chapter Ninety-One

Failure

Between 1412 and 1440,
the Catholic church and the Christian empires
fail to find the old unities

THE CATHOLIC CHURCH had been badly cracked by the long years of dual papacy; the cracks were now papered over, but still visible through the thin tissue of agreement. The paradigm of a single Christian empire still survived in stereo, in the hands of the German king to the west and the Byzantine emperor. Both of them claimed the ancient baptized crown of Rome, the call to enforce the *pax Romana* as a *pax Christiana*.

But all of these ideals were aging, and at least one of them was already emitting a deathbed rattle.

SIGISMUND, king of Germany and Hungary, was not yet emperor of a holy Roman kingdom. Both Italy and Bohemia, territories of the old empire, lay beyond his grasp.

Before his death from plague in 1402, Gian Galeazzo Visconti—granted the title Duke of Milan by the emperor Wenceslaus IV—had claimed almost all of northern Italy. Only Florence and Venice had remained independent, and Genoa had saved herself from his grasp only by submitting to the rule of the French.

But with Visconti dead, his two sons (aged twelve and thirteen) were